



the south. In between lie the breathtaking grasslands, or **steppes**. Roughly two-thirds of the 2.4 million people in Mongolia live in cities and towns. The rest live as **nomads** always moving their herds to different

seasonal pastures. Cursed with bitterly cold winters and a short growing season, the steppes have attracted few new people and much of the **grasslands** have changed little over hundreds of years.



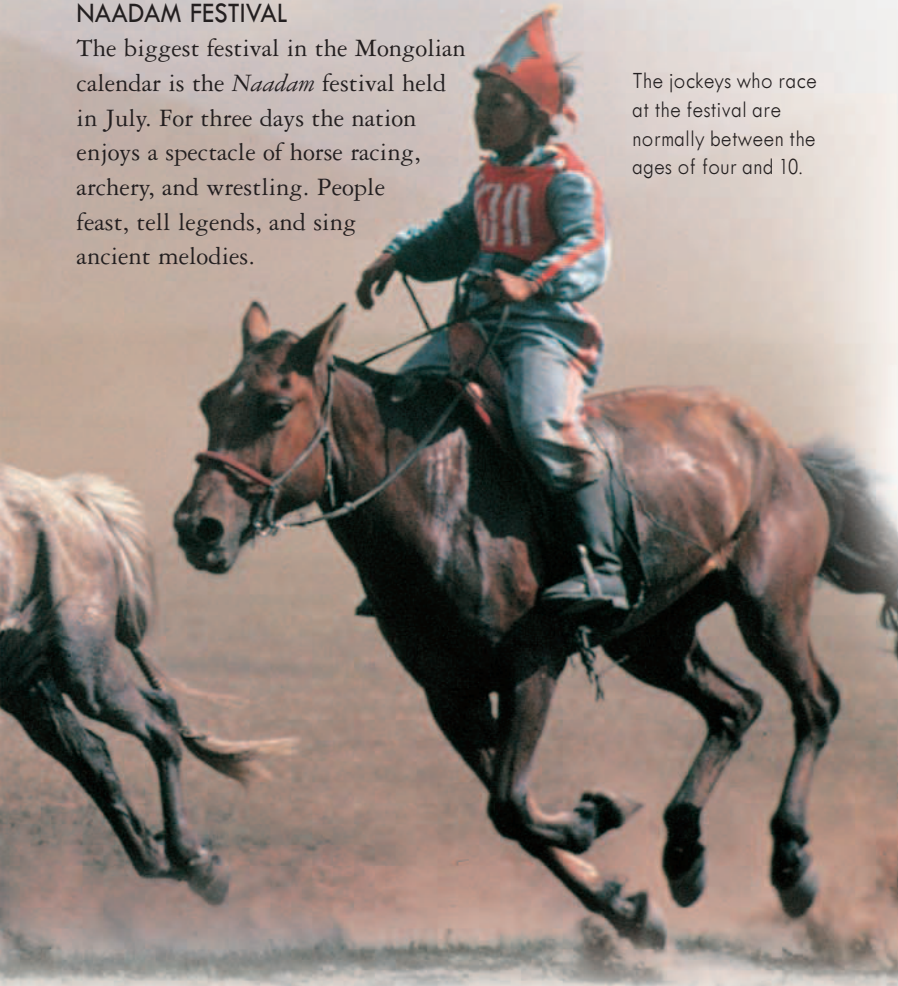
LIVESTOCK

As well as horses, the Mongolians breed yaks, sheep, cattle, goats, and the hardy, two-humped camel, for milk, meat, wool, leather, and transportation. The nomads live mainly on flour, meat, and milk products; anything green or leafy is considered to be animal food. The horses are kept for riding and milk.

NAADAM FESTIVAL

The biggest festival in the Mongolian calendar is the *Naadam* festival held in July. For three days the nation enjoys a spectacle of horse racing, archery, and wrestling. People feast, tell legends, and sing ancient melodies.

The jockeys who race at the festival are normally between the ages of four and 10.



THE HOME

The Mongolian home is a large, white tent called a *ger*, which can be moved easily and quickly and erected in half an hour. Even the city Mongolians often live in *gers*. The door of a *ger* always faces south.



1 Building the frame

The frame is made up of supporting poles and wooden lattice work, standing in a ring. They are fastened with leather thongs and studs.



2 Covering the ger

The frame is then covered with thick, white felt and fastened with ropes. Every *ger* has an opening at the top for light and ventilation.



3 Inside the ger

The insides of the finest *gers* are spectacular. The furniture is painted in bright colors and intricate patterns.

WOLF HUNTERS

There are strict hunting rules that prohibit the shooting of she-wolves or cubs in the winter when wolf's fur is at its thickest. The Mongolians ride motorcycles when they are hunting wolves.

